

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

PROTHONOTARY WARBLER

Protonotaria citrea7-0 (A)
Recd 2/2/01 upsl
S/ALocation: Lamar Community College/Willow Creek; Lamar; Prowers County, ColoradoDate: April 22, 2000Setting:

I had been birding with others at Two Buttes Reservoir in the morning, but left late in the morning. I ran into Norm Erthal, Joey Kellner and others who also observed this bird. It was first spotted, I believe, by Joey, who called our attention to the bird. This area is a riparian-like grove along Willow Creek with heavy understory. The bird was foraging just a foot or two off the ground in a dead snag that was emergent in a flooded area of the creek. Thus the bird was about 20-30 feet distant, in the open, right over the water. It was sunny and still and I observed it for about 5 minutes with my B & L binoculars.

Description:

The bird was an adult male. It was a large, stout, rather plump warbler (about 5"), with a short tail. It had a rather stout, black, sharp, chisel-shaped bill – quite large for a warbler. The head and undersides were a brilliant, pure yellow; the forehead and forecrown were even brighter, with golden-orangish tones. The long undertail coverts were white. The back and nape were dull grayish-yellow. The wings and tail were blue-gray. It lacked wingbars. The eye was black and striking in the middle of the brilliant yellow face. The legs and feet were black. The bird was silent.

Similar Species:

The only other mainly yellow-headed warblers are: Blue-winged (wingbars; black eye-line); Orange-crowned and Tennessee (lack blue-gray wings and tails); Yellow (streaked below; lacks blue-gray wings and tail; has yellow undertail coverts); and Wilson's (smaller; lacks white undertail coverts; has tiny bill).

Experience with Species:

I have seen all the warblers mentioned above. I've seen several Prothonotary Warblers previously in Colorado and quite a few in other parts of the country.

This report is prepared from notes made at the time of observation.

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